a few days we shall be reduced to our rations of half a pound of salt beef and half a pound of coarse sugar, and further reductions are in prospect.' A few days later the entry read, even more ominously: 'No tiffin today; meat becoming scarce.'[37] By 23 March, Sale sent word to General Pollock in Peshawar that he could not hold out much longer: he had already destroyed all his transport camels so that what fodder there was could be given to the cavalry, and he calculated that what remained of the salt meat would run out on 4 April.[38] Ammunition for the muskets was also soon running perilously short.

Akbar again positioned himself as the champion of Islam and used his new-found reputation as a holy warrior to draw supporters and allies, even among those who were otherwise sceptical about his leadership. As MacGregor wrote to Pollock in mid-March: 'He represents himself as one who has now no home, no family, no ties and no object, but the revival of the true religion and the extermination of its enemies.'[39] On the evening halts on his way from Laghman to Jalalabad, Akbar used his time in camp to send out a stream of diplomatic messages trying to rally the Afghan nobles to his standard, using the language of the jihad in a more direct and innovative way than he or any other Afghan had yet done.[40] Anyone who had allied with Shah Shuja, he hinted, should be treated as an apostate. No one would be allowed to sit on the fence. To one noble, Saiyed Ahai-ud-Din, who had been a close ally of the Shah, he wrote:

> Rest assured of this: if you have any apprehension in consequence of having been forced to form connexions with the Firangis, I beg of you to dismiss all fears on this account from your heart, for you acted as the time required. Everyone great and small has been obliged for the sake of his own interests to connect himself more or less with the Firangis. But now that the book of that hated race has been dispersed into wind-blown leaves, and now that the ranks of the Army of Islam are firmly united together, what can be the reason for your withdrawing yourself? I write to beseech of you that abandoning all alienation, and considering my house as your home, you will return without delay that we may meet each other and the ties of friendship between us be drawn even closer. I trust you will start in this direction immediately.[41]

To another nobleman, Turabaz Khan, Akbar wrote an even more explicitly religious – even mystical – appeal: he must forsake the Kafirs and return to the fold of the true Believers. 'Intelligence was received that you had left Lalpoora and taken refuge in the hills,' he wrote.